

Catechesis: Questions and answers,
With Bishop Emilianos. 2026-03-08

VIDEO: <https://youtu.be/e404w5TNfDQ?si=6nQupACfcq6i8lAd>

Partially edited, close to verbatim transcript

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In the name of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. Amen.

So, Father Seraphim said that we'd primarily be thinking in terms of a Q&A this week, and so I thought maybe I can ask the first question, if that's okay.

"You're supposed to be answering questions."

Oh, okay. I can answer some questions, but I want to ask the first question to everybody and then reflect it back. Okay. So, there's a lot of—how many people here are catechumens?

Okay. How many people who are catechumens have already made arrangements to be baptized this year on Holy Saturday?

Okay. All right. How many are inquirers? Wonderful.

Okay. So, the question I want to ask is actually two questions, right? When you're an inquirer, what's the most important question you should be asking and trying to answer? And the second question is going to be: when you are about to be baptized, what's the most important question you should be asking and trying to answer?

So let's start with the inquirer question. Anyone think they know the answer for the first question?

"Is it, like, how can I be—like where I'm hosting a lot? Not sure about—I'd imagine for the—"

Because I'm kind of a catechumen, but better than the first one. Because I was an inquirer. The question I tended to ask myself a lot was—they were at first very theologically heavy questions, and very scholastically driven things, because I was coming from Catholicism. So I was just like, okay, so this isn't—you know. But yeah, it eventually simplified to something I really couldn't answer. There was a question within me, but I didn't know what the word was. It's just kind of—I was just looking in awe.

So basically, I had no question.

So the question was the lack of a question.

Yeah. It was just—I was just in awe of what I was seeing.

Oh, and that kind of built off of there.

So you started finding your way from inquirer to catechumen by your question evaporating.

Yeah, basically. My questions were very much so like—I was getting the satisfaction of answering the theological things. I was like, "Oh yeah, no, I can totally see that there is no Vatican I-style papacy in the first millennium." I could answer all those things, but eventually it got to a point where I was like, but what—why am I here? Now that I can move that, why am I here? I felt like I was actually getting to know—not me know God—but I was able to see other people knowing God, and I was like, I want to be part of that.

Okay. You know, sounds like that. That's centering it a little more, isn't it? Right. What's the most important thing that brings you in?

Yeah. I think a question that I didn't ask really much that I probably should have asked is just, is this where I will be able to encounter God? I think that's not really what I focused on, but I think if I had focused on that, it would have been better.

That sounds sort of like what Daniel was saying.

Yes.

But you articulated it differently.

Yes.

Okay. Yeah.

I think the basic question for me with inquiring for the past couple of years has just been: what is the truth, and why is it true?

Which, Travis—

Polycarp.

Yeah. Which Polycarp has put into words: why is it the truth? What is the truth? What is what will bring me closer to Christ? What will bring me into connection with Christ?

Right. I'm just going to echo exactly that. That's the whole reason I ended up here. I'm operating on the assumption that the world is ordered, and that there's truth to it, because me and you can speak to each other, understand each other, reality is coherent and all that. And yeah, just that—in what is the truth, where is the truth, why is it true? All those questions would probably—

“Was always: what must I do to be saved, and what should I strive for to fulfill the life of acquiring or becoming—”

Do you want to add anything?

No. It's just amazing. Like, in my small brain, America looks very blessed at this point, because in Australia, if you were to ask people who want to be Orthodox in the Greek Orthodox Church, "Why do you want to be Orthodox?" they would tell you, "Because I'm getting married to an Orthodox person."

Seriously, guys, this is why they would become Orthodox. And it's embarrassing, because on the other side of the planet, people are looking for God, and they don't have the question, "Can I marry the person I want to spend the rest of my life with in the Orthodox Church?" or "They're in the Orthodox Church. If I don't go and become Orthodox, I can't marry them." They put themselves in front of God and they're telling Him, "I'm looking for You. Are You here?" And this is why they want to become Orthodox, which is why God became human.

And I'm just—Father, I feel very blessed to hear these things, because I was not even expecting these responses.

Well done, guys. You're looking for something. So that's—the Greeks, they say the beginning is half of everything, so you're already 50% there.

Well, that's the Greeks. G.I. Joe says knowing is a battle.

I'm dating myself. Sorry.

So let's go to the second question. This is perhaps a slightly more challenging one, slightly more contemporary and present for the few of us who have baptisms scheduled in the very near future.

What is the most important question you should be asking yourself? And I don't mean just mentally. I mean mentally and also in how you're living and what you're doing in the next several months if you are on the threshold of being baptized.

"I have God in my heart. How can I die to myself every day? How do I stay true to my baptism?"

When I first started in my Orthodox journey, I spent two years kind of as an Oriental Orthodox, so that gave me some time to flush out my theological questions. But as I've had like a nine-month catechesis and as I've been going through this, I have started to uncover underneath those theological questions that there was also fundamentally almost deeply a social driver to this as well for me, where not until very recently, with the help of a friend, did I realize that's not wrong, but it shouldn't—at no point should it be overriding my drive to get close to God. And as someone who's extremely extroverted, that's been something that literally very recently I've been like, oh, my question needs to not be how do I—you know—it needs to not be solving for these innate parts of my personality, but it needs to be solving for: I seek first the Kingdom of God, and everything else will follow suit from that. And that's something that has very recently hit me in the chest.

So mine's the same as hers. It's just dying, you know? That's really hard. It's really hard. Especially when it's like coming from the Catholic world. I'm like, "No, I thought I died to myself. I thought I was doing really good." No, I didn't. I didn't do too good at all.

Yeah. I think my question would be, what should I do to make the most of my baptism and [after] baptism?

"I'm not like a catechumen yet, but I guess a good question—the question that I keep asking myself is: do I want to live for myself, or do I want to live for God? And I don't know—for me personally, I don't really know the answer to that. I mean, I tell myself I want to live for God, but it's clear with my actions that that's something that really—"

Like, what was a revelation to me, which I didn't know until I was around Orthodoxy, was this daily—you get a choice in every moment of every day to either be like Peter or be like Judas, you know? Because one fell backwards and the other one fell forward. And that concept—that entire concept—was just not even, you know, coming from the Catholic side of it, it was very legalistic and almost like a courtroom and things like that. Just this idea of constantly falling forward, you know what I mean? Eventually your falling starts to turn into crawling, and it's footsteps, then before you know it you're actually making strides. That whole concept was just—I tried to ask myself, how can I be like Peter today? If I fail, can I fail like Peter?

So a lot of questions centered around this: how do I live? How do I do this? How do I do this thing we call being a Christian in public in Christ? And how can I actually do it and not just say I'm doing it?

I want to echo back one question. Is anybody worthy of baptism, of communion, of Christ's sacrifice?

Easy question, right? Easy question. And is that okay?

Yes.

Because He did it anyway.

Right. Right.

So in a sense, what do we say? We say often in the church in our prayers, "Make me worthy," right? So in a sense, we're worthy not because we're worthy. We're worthy because He wants us to be worthy, because He wants to give to us.

I just wanted to say that, guys, the way you express your questions and your views makes me wonder if you should be sitting here, because it's mind-blowing. Like, a lot of maturity, a lot of the way you see Orthodoxy—it's what it is.

And today we celebrate St. Gregory Palamas, who had basically an argument with the Catholics. The Catholics were saying that we can't experience God from this life, and St. Gregory went ahead and said for the first time very clearly, this is not correct. So we can experience God from this life, and we can experience Him through His energies. And that's why our faith believes that we can taste eternity from now. St. Symeon the New Theologian says that whoever will not experience God from this life will not experience Him in the next. It's a very bold statement to make when you can't prove that there is a God—but then can you prove that there is no God?

So what I'm saying is that you guys are looking for God. And just remember the minutes in your life that you said to yourselves, "I want to find God." Don't ever forget that, and keep looking. And yes, God will be in your heart, because that's why He became man, just for that,

as simple as that. So He can't shut the door in front of our faces. He became human for this purpose, for this reason.

And when the Gospel says, "Ask and you will receive," this "ask," at least in the Greek language, you can understand it as if it is an order, not just an encouragement. Ask, guys. If you don't ask, you're idiots. God is ours and we are His. What are you waiting for? Like seriously, do something with your lives.

Sorry. What's your opinion?

Part 2

I want to, I guess, answer by way of another question. Pulling out the other thing that I'm hearing is this question that came from Daniel—uh, Gabriel.

Gabriel.

Okay. So, Gabriel—I'll say your name three times. Gabriel, Gabriel, Gabriel—talked about how do I remain true to my baptismal vows, right? That question of okay, that question of what next, right? So what—so everyone's already engaged in this struggle, this struggle of—well, many of us are already engaged in the struggle of trying to live according to Christ, trying to follow His teachings, trying to pray to Him, trying to be faithful.

When we receive baptism, what changes? What's different? What does baptism give us?

"The Holy Spirit within us."

The Holy Spirit within us. Is the Holy Spirit already acting with us?

"Inside us and with us, but not inside."

But not inside us. Okay. Okay. So, the Holy Spirit within us. What else? What does that mean?

It means you become like a temple of the Holy Spirit. You can actually hold God. That's another thing too. Like about the Our Father, where it says, "Thy Kingdom come," and stuff, how the Kingdom is within you. That's really what's happening, is you're creating a spot, or you're allowing a spot, for the Kingdom to reside within you. So there's a great grace that you're given there, the Holy Spirit abiding in you, making it easier perhaps to undergo this struggle, right, this Christian struggle.

Is that the only thing then? Doesn't it absolve any sins completely?

So all prior sins are forgiven.

Yes.

You're united to the Church, should become part of His Body, which is why you can then partake of His Body and Blood. So you have great grace on so many levels, right, to aid you in the struggle, and so that you can have the weapons to take up the fight against those passions to which you're given. All of us have these passions, right? We're given a greater arsenal of weapons in baptism.

Okay then—what good is the arsenal unless you what?

"Unless you use it."

Unless you use it.

Yes.

And keep it stocked. Don't waste it.

Right. There's another side, right? In addition to the grace, we also shortly after baptism get something else.

"We get increasing amount of—"

Okay, well, hopefully yes.

“Starts with a T, ends with an ion. Temptations.”

Temptations. Yes. Greater temptations.

Why is that?

“Because you chose a side.”

Huh?

“You chose a side.”

I like that. You chose a side, right? Okay. So the why has two answers, I think. One, yeah, the trickster is kind of riled up, right? And he wants to try to put you down. But he has no power over you, right? So that’s okay. You have the great grace, right?

The other part of the why, though, is well, God lets him get—can he do anything God doesn’t let him do? So God lets him get riled up. Why? Why does He let you be tempted?

“Got to train the soldiers when they’re first starting out so that they get better.”

And does the maximum temptation come right away?

“No. No. No.”

Why not?

“You’re not trained yet.”

Yeah. Right. So you get a lot of grace and a little bit of temptation. Then over time what starts happening?

More temptation, and perhaps you feel the grace less acutely, right? And so that's where I think your question is such an important one, right? To know that there will be temptation. It's going to be hard. And what do you have to do then?

"Keep praying. Just persevere."

Persevere. Right.

"Longsuffering."

Yeah. Patient perseverance, as Father Seraphim has been teaching us. Right. And when it seems you reach that point where, okay, I don't think I can persevere. I think this struggle is too hard for me. I think it's too much. It's beyond my strength.

Then that's when you tell yourself what it is.

"Glory to God for all things."

Okay. It's not what I was going to say.

I was going to say, God has allowed this temptation at the level that it is right now. Right?

Right.

Yes. The enemy is there, but God allowed it. And is He going to allow the enemy to tempt me more than is possible for me to withstand?

"More than I can withstand myself?"

Absolutely. But more than I can withstand with His help?

Right.

Which means what do I have to do?

“Ask.”

Ask. Have faith. Keep persevering. Right? And so to me—and my experience level and my smartness are very low, so I could be wrong—but I think one of the biggest things someone new to the faith has to know is that it’s going to be hard, and you just have to persevere.

Anything?

Only one thing comes to mind, is that if God allows a temptation bigger than our strength to occur, it’s because He needs to sort of humble us. It means that we’re doing something wrong. And it’s like God telling us, “You need to see things differently.” And of course, without Him we can’t do anything, so we need to run to Him. But there is nothing that can separate us from God other than ourselves.

So let’s say that someone is persecuting us, or we have our own issues. It could be health issues. It could be temptations. Whatever it is, nothing can separate us from God other than ourselves. The devil doesn’t have this authority. So we can always choose to be with God, and that’s all He wants from us. And if we fall, it doesn’t matter. Just don’t be afraid. Get up. Keep going.

“Why give so much authority to flawed creatures?”

Can you explain the question?

We said the devil does not have this authority to separate us from God, but God gave us, I suppose, the authority for ourselves in order to separate ourselves from Him. Why? Why do we have freedom?

I suppose, why do we have freedom? That’s the big question, right? Sorry.

“I know this one.”

Do you know that one? Well, go for it.

“That’s a big price to pay.”

Can only be free—that's the only way. I mean, think of the alternative, right? If we didn't have freedom, it would be worse. Then would life be worth it? Would it be the same thing? Would it be the same gift?

I mean, this marvelous thing that—you know the old scholastic question, "Can God make a rock that He can't lift?" Right? And they debate these things, right? Well, the answer is yes, and it's called you, man, right? And it's not that He can't lift it. It's just He, in creating you, chose not to be able to lift it, right? He chose to make a creature that was free like He is, so that we can be creative like He is, active like He is. We can be free and loving like He is, which is astounding to those of us who haven't acquired that love yet, right, to understand why that would be so important to Him. But if you have His love, I'm sure you would understand, right?

Its lack of freedom would obviate the gift.

Once I was in Mount Athos. I was a young monk, and there were three visitors. I think one was from Canada, one from the States, and one from somewhere else, and they started talking about freedom, and they involved me in the conversation. And what I realized when I was talking to them is that freedom is not a virtue. Freedom is the Holy Spirit—is a person. How we say God is love also, God is freedom. So God cannot deny His qualities, His love and freedom. And He made us in His image and likeness. This is who we are. If He takes this away from us, we're not humans. He wouldn't do that to us because then He's not God, because He's not good if He does.

So freedom is the Holy Spirit. And that's why the saints, that we had God in extreme amounts—love, freedom, and everything—they were not afraid to die. It's not that they didn't go through pain. The martyrs, they went through pain. But they chose to die. Why? Because they believed. Because they were free. Because they wouldn't allow anything to separate them from their love from God.

If God takes away our freedom, we're like chickens.

"I would love to be a chicken person."

But that's my choice.

It is what it is.

Does the Incarnation require us to be free?

Of course, because for God to take on human nature, since God is perfect, it would be necessary for the nature that He takes to also have freedom as a capacity.

I didn't quite understand. I'm sorry.

Oh, I'm sorry. Because God was incarnate with human nature, it's necessary for human nature to include the capacity for freedom because of the Incarnation.

I think that's getting at the same thing, right? Because the Word was incarnate as a man, but man was also made in His image to begin with, right? We were made in His image or made to be like Him. And so then He took on that image, which was His. And this is very confusing, but yes, I mean, it's all connected.

I involuntarily think of the statement by St. Maximus the Confessor that even if we hadn't fallen, He still would have become man.

So think about the state of man before the fall, right? This state of communion with God in the garden. Now think of the state after the fall, this separation from God, right? And now think of the state of man after Christ is incarnate, when we are joined to His Church in baptism, we partake of His Body and Blood, human nature is sitting at the right hand of the Father through His Ascension. Right? So is it the same state there was in the garden, or is it better?

I think it might be able to tie into the reason we've got freedom, because of the fall. We're intended to become—to achieve the likeness of God, and we're made in His image. And part of the likeness that we're supposed to have is a spiritual maturity and perseverance and all these virtues that wouldn't have been able to be gotten without the freedom to choose in the first place. All these good virtues.

And so, of course, we're getting hypothetical now, right?

Yeah. Yeah. What other questions do you have?

Part 3

Well, I was just going to make an observation. Ever since humanity has been kicked out of the garden, the love-gifts that God has for us require sacrifice to participate. Man will live by the sweat of his brow. And so in order for us to participate, we need struggle and sacrifice, and sacrifice can only be given.

But I do have a question. How do we avoid, if we come from unstable families or whatever and we're growing in our years in the faith, how do we avoid Orthodox fatigue?

The struggle is real.

So my poor and insufficient answer would be: this is where the struggle is real. This is where faith has to become real as well. This recognition that it's not our own strength that saves us. There's nothing we do that saves us. It's not our success in our struggles that saves us. It's Christ that saves us. And we can't map out what He has in store for us in His path in our life. We don't see. We're like people walking through a dark tangled forest at night, given only a weak flashlight. We can see just far enough to put one foot in front of the other. And that's how much we can see of God's plan for our life. But we have to trust His plan and trust that to the extent that we're finding ourselves weak, we need to learn some humility, perhaps, or to learn to trust Him more. And we just take the next step and know that He's watching over us. And even if we're not feeling all that faithful, He is.

What I was thinking is that Geronda was always emphasizing to us to understand our measures, in the sense that he wouldn't be happy if we were to fast more than what our body can handle. He wouldn't be happy if we were to sleep less than what our body could handle. And by this he wouldn't mean that we don't push our limits. What he meant was that if you do more than what God has enabled you to do, what gives you the energy to do that? That's your ego. If we do that, we will get fatigued from ourselves, not from God.

Because I can tell you from my own experience, if the devil tries to push your limits, God will give you the strength. And for example, this is what I understood lately: people that

persecute you, they make you fail. So they can't win against—they can't outsmart the Holy Spirit. The devil cannot outsmart the Holy Spirit. When Christ was around, the devil did his worst, killed Christ. It was the key for the salvation of all of us.

You can't outsmart the Holy Spirit. So nothing can beat us if we're one with God other than our own ego. So for you to get Orthodox fatigue in the Orthodox Church, it means that what leads you is your ego. Once you understand this, you can't be tired of God. Because when you're in love, you can't be tired from the person you're in love with. There is no chance. Otherwise, your love is fake.

How do we know if our love is real? Because honestly, I question myself every day if my love is real. And it's just at the point—if I don't love God, what's the point? And I tell myself I do, but I just get inside my own head and I don't know if I really do or not, because honestly I have a hard time pinpointing my emotions or how I feel. I don't know—it's just I get to a point where it's hard to explain, but sometimes I just feel like—even though, yes, I do consider myself like I want to be a Christian—but with everything going on in my life, I don't even know how to trust God because of the fact that, for me at least, life just doesn't feel like it's worth living.

So, do you remember the Bible verse where there's a man who has—I think it's his son—and he keeps falling into the fire and in the water? He was suffering from epilepsy or something, like a demon that was causing seizures. And I could have this wrong, but the dad of that boy says, "Please help my son." And I think Jesus says something like, "O wicked and perverse generation, how long must I be here?" I'm paraphrasing really badly. But long story short, when the father of that boy says, "I believe; help my unbelief"—that is—because I know what you're going through. Because I had that same kind of thing where it's almost like on the edge of nihilism.

Yeah.

Kind of, you know, where it's like you're like, why do I do what I do? Why even pursue what you see? And it's a very deep evil. Like it's a very deep-seated thing that can afflict you. So I know what you're going through. But really what you have to hold on to are the actions or the footsteps, because whenever he says, "I believe; help my unbelief," he met God where he kind of met God halfway. It's kind of like the parable of the boy who returns to his—it's the prodigal son. It's almost like running halfway down the driveway. You know what I mean? You've got to

reach God. So it gets easier, but if the only thing you can focus on is your footsteps, you just have to keep your eyes on your feet.

I don't know. It's just like I feel like—because I've been trying to become—like even though that whole year that I've wanted to be a Christian, the whole year that I've spent, I just feel like I've become a worse person. And I just feel like with my life, like there's really—why even continue?

So one thing I think about is St. Joseph the Hesychast, and how—because I've been doing Orthodoxy from Austin to Dallas now for a year and a half, and I also feel like I'm getting worse. But then I look at St. Joseph the Hesychast, and he battled for 15 years with the demon of fornication. Fifteen years. I mean, probably by year 14 he's like, "Is this ever going to go away?" And then I think if you just—someone said earlier—longsuffering, if you just have that attitude of, "I'm just going to keep fighting with this no matter what happens, if it's 15 years or 50 years," then you'll be crowned one day.

And I would add to that—I think this is important for people in our times—don't psychoanalyze yourself. We all tend to do that. We all tend to think too much and psychoanalyze ourselves, and it just is another source of anxiety and thoughts that disturb us and go around and run. Just take it on face value and trust that God is there no matter what you're going through, and give it to Him. Just, "Lord, You see who I am. Take me as I am. Take whatever degree of love I'm able to offer and increase it." Whatever your self-assessment is, whether it's good or bad at any given moment, it can injure you.

I had problems with narcissism for a long, long time, and I thought perhaps if I just ignore the positive thoughts on myself and just regard the negative—but ultimately I had to stop thinking about myself. So whenever I would get a thought about myself, I would redirect my attention away from this.

Yeah. That's on the money right there. Truly all these Eastern religions that I would dive into and stuff talk about the death of the ego and things like that. Nothing compares to this. There's a truth. They all kind of use a piece of the truth, but then they paint it in all these ways. Orthodoxy is the true death of the ego. It is to truly die to yourself. And thoughts can be as good as, "Wow, you did a great job on that," and it can be as bad as, "You're the worst person ever. You're never going to be anything." And they switch up on you, and it sounds

just like your voice. And sometimes it is your voice. The devil likes to play in the ambiguous. He likes to play in that playground, that no-man's-land. So sometimes it is your voice, sometimes it's not. And he loves the fact that you can kind of play in between those two things.

So, long story short, don't listen to any thought at all. You just have to learn how to turn off your brain and just focus. And that's why the Jesus Prayer is amazing, because it is a complete redirect of your brain toward the only truth in this world. It's not like a thought experiment or a mantra or something. It's an actual reorganization toward Christ the true Logos.

"Lord Jesus Christ, Son of God, have mercy on me, a sinner." That prevents you from thinking about all the other things which are causing you anxiety.

At the same time, we also shouldn't beat ourselves up if we can't turn off our thoughts. It's just—say, "Okay, this is how it is right now." Then you notice and you say, "Oh, there I go again," and you turn to God. And then you notice them two and a half seconds later and say, "Oh, there I go again." And that's okay.

Few things once told me personally: if you focus on your emotions, it's like you commit suicide, because our emotions, they determine our actions, and it's the wrong focus. So what I gathered after all these years trying to stand on my own spiritually is that you basically have said it already. I will just rephrase it. We can't focus on ourselves. We can't focus on our thoughts. We need to focus on God. Otherwise, it's like we can't walk on the waves. But this life is full of waves. If we want to walk on the waves, we need to focus on God.

However, for someone who has intrusive thoughts, for someone who has traits of OCD, you can't do this alone. You need professional help, and this is not something which is embarrassing. This is the reality of things. So if I myself need a painkiller to be able to tell my small brain, "Focus on God," otherwise I will be focused on my headache, I need to take the painkiller. And this is a humble thing to do and a realistic thing to do, and this is what I need to do in order to pray. Eventually I won't [need it for] my prayers. I'm just giving a single example.

So if we suffer from intrusive thoughts, if we have OCD, we need professional help to help us go on a level where we can start working with ourselves. Otherwise we can't. It's too much, and everything gets too much. But I will tell you one thing: God doesn't make mistakes. You are not a mistake. You are not created by accident. So get this thought out of your mind and just

understand that the cross that God has given you is what will make you a saint, should you use it the way you should. So if you try and understand that and be humble to accept help, that's it. Don't focus on yourself. Don't focus on your emotions. Don't panic when the thoughts are intrusive. Focus on God. Get the help you deserve. Move on. God created you for a reason, and you are worthy of being created. Remember that God doesn't make mistakes.

Part 4

I think everybody's journey is very slow, because I've struggled with a lot of the things you struggle with. But you being here and opening up to all these people about that means you're taking steps toward a relationship with God. You have people in here now who can pray for you, which is even more power toward your relationship with God. So even if you can't prove to yourself that you have the emotional love for God, you are loving God, which is a lot more concrete and a lot more easy to define. And so, just by being here, you are loving God. Everybody's on a journey to love God more perfectly. And people who have been baptized forever and have done all of these things, they're still working on loving God perfectly.

Father Seraphim always says that when you wake up, and if you just can't find yourself and do your entire prayer rule, at least say one Jesus Prayer, do one prostration. That action in itself—God sees that. I think it was Luke 12 I read earlier today where it was talking about what you do behind closed doors, what you say in your mind, everything will be revealed. God sees how much suffering and how hard it is for you just to get out of bed. But the fact that you got out of bed and you're like, "I love You, God," or "Lord Jesus Christ, have mercy on me. Thank You for waking me up," one prostration—God sees that. You may not feel love in your heart, but that doesn't mean that you aren't trying to cultivate that love in your heart.

Yeah. The key word that you've got to remember is magnify. Magnify is the key word you've got to hold on to, because God can take whatever you give Him and He can magnify it. Even if we give Him—even if we give Him everything we've got, He still magnifies it. It is still nothing in the grand scheme of it all. So give Him—it's kind of like the widow that gave all she had. Try to give as much as you can every day, even if it is just one prostration, if it is

just one “Help me, God,” because He sees the reach, you know? He magnifies that, and you take one step toward Him, He takes a thousand towards you.

Question.

I wanted to add about after being tempted after baptism. I got into many difficulties after I was baptized many years ago. But then sometimes even the Jesus Prayer would be overridden by—it was so difficult because the thoughts were so intrusive. And then I started thinking about really analyzing my thoughts. But I was trying to fight it. Then I started reading your book on nepsis, and it just makes so much sense. And I was like, okay, I tried to be in the moment, really tune out all the other thoughts. And I filmed myself once—I was at home—[to see] how many minutes I can be in the moment, whatever I’m doing. And literally sometimes it would be a minute if I worked hard, but sometimes even ten seconds and the thought will come. So it was just telling me constantly thoughts will be attacking. But with your book, it’s helpful to have that spiritual approach to thoughts, because on that finally I got an opening so fast.

But something you said in the very beginning was how you question your own love for God based off how you feel. And going off what His Grace is saying about focusing on the emotions, one of the greatest lies I ever fall into is having my emotions rule or dictate my love for God, when in reality the greatest exhibition of your love is what you do despite how you feel. Because I’m reminded of the parable of the two sons who were both petitioned by the father to go work the vineyard. The first son said, “No, I’m not going to do that,” but later did it. The second son was petitioned, he said, “Of course, father,” but he doesn’t do it. Who is the one who did the will of the father? It’s about despite how you feel, what are you doing in that moment?

Some of my greatest, most connected prayers to God were whenever I was weeping and out of vitriol or despair or anything—how I was feeling—despite how I felt toward God in that moment. I felt like I never hated anybody more than God, you know? But in that very moment I was still on my knees, because in the very end I think it’s far worse for you to be apathetic about it, for you to say, “You know what? It’s not really worth my time. I’m not even going to bother. I don’t care anymore.”

God can't despise anybody who doesn't answer your question, "Do I love God?" You want to love God, right? That means you love Him. The only reason to want to love Him is that you love Him. So that's all you.

I say that living a good life is like a chain of wants. So if I wanted to love God truly, I wouldn't be sinning. So I wanted to want to love God. And sometimes I get discouraged, and so I want to want to want to love God. It's this chain. And so every day you're trying to shorten that chain as much as possible. But as long as you're on it, as long as you admit and you're honest and you still try, it makes the next step a lot more easy, because you can only see what's in front of you.

What other questions do we have?

Yeah. I think this is common for a lot of people when they convert to Orthodoxy, especially from Protestant backgrounds, to kind of have what some people have called online ["convertitis"] or whatever, where you get really zealous about Orthodoxy, right? And you're like, "Yes, I have found what is true, and I know this to be true," and you want to share it with people. But at the same time you don't want to be a jerk about it, right? To the point where it's like, "Oh, now I've pushed so many people away because I've acted like a jerk." I guess my question is, how do you avoid acting like an idiot in that way, if that makes sense? I've kind of reached that point where it's like, well, I know it's best for me to keep my mouth shut and let my actions speak for themselves. It's very hard to keep my mouth shut. So with that, what are some practical things that I could think about or pray with?

I would say, I think you've answered it, right? Focus on being and growing and learning in Christ, and don't assume that you're at a point to do any intentional evangelization or sharing at this point. Wait till you understand it better and feel [more rooted], which can be a long time. There's a reason it says in the letter to Timothy, "Don't ordain someone who's recently converted," right?

So that doesn't mean that if people ask—at the same time, St. Peter says, "Always be ready to give an answer for the hope that is in you," right? But that's personal. That's if someone asks, "Well, what happened to you? Why are you doing this now?" You have an answer to that. Tell them why, and don't be afraid to do it. But don't go trying to convert your extended family tomorrow.

What my experience has taught me is that before I do anything, before I say anything, I try to see within myself. And it helps because I'm an introvert. But I try to see within myself if what I'm going to do or say feels peaceful. This for me is like a compass, like a guide. If I don't feel peaceful about something, if I feel prideful about it, I won't do it. But if I feel peaceful, for me this is an indication that I can do it. And sometimes it could be spiritual peace, sometimes it could be psychological peace—good luck discerning. However, even if it is purely psychological peace, this is what I can handle. So I will do that, because if I expose myself to more than what I can handle, it won't end up pretty.

I'm not sure if this is helpful, but if you feel prideful about preaching about God or this or that, I wouldn't do it. If you feel peaceful about it, even if it looks prideful to others, don't worry about it. Because humility is in our motives, not in our actions. And I will explain this. I've said it a million times, but it's like if I now start washing everyone's feet to look Christlike, and I do it to get a reputation, my mind is not pure. This is not humility. But if I was to talk, and maybe people think that I'm proud when I talk the way I talk, but I do it out of love, there's humility there and there is peace in that, and I will do that.

So look inside you before you do what you do, when your thought is still developing, and ask yourself, is this a peaceful thing to do or say? And do it. If not, don't. And this will guide you to not being overzealous. This will keep you within borders, within a protected field, in a way. Hope this makes sense.

How do you deal with the intrusive thoughts that kind of question your motives? Because sometimes I'll pray to have my sins forgiven, and sometimes my mind will be, "Am I doing it because I love God, or am I doing it to receive something from God? Am I doing it—for example, I'll give money to the homeless—am I doing it to have my heart—"

I would say you can't always tell, but you can still, if you know it's the right thing to do, do it and call out to God and ask Him to purify your motives.

That's not what you said, Father. And also, you can't go willing your thoughts. If you do something, you might be proud about it. If you don't do it, you might feel down about it. You can't win. So don't worry about your thoughts. If you can afford doing it, do it. And your experience will teach you later on. So don't try to be a prophet if it's right or wrong. Take

responsibility for your actions. Do it if you want to do it. Don't do it if you don't want to do it. It doesn't matter if you did the right or the wrong thing. What matters is that you want to do what God wants you to do. You will discover this later on. Just move on and focus on God.

So I said something to someone. It might work, it might not work. If I'm there to analyze within myself whether I said something right, I will go crazy. So I do something with the best of intention I can find inside me. Whatever is there—God, please bless it. If You don't want to bless it today—but I'm honest. So I either make up a decision to do it or not to do it. I move on. That's about it.

That's why when people were asking, "How can I do God's will?" he was asking them back, "Do you even know what you want to do?" Forget about God's will. Do you even know what you want to do? So if you know what you want to do, do it. And God will guide you where He wants to guide you. But you need to stand in front of God with full responsibility: I did this because I care. If it's wrong, correct me. If it's right, bless it. That's it. I can't deal with my [thoughts]. You lock them out of the window and you keep going. Whatever happens, happens. Good luck. What are you going to do?

Part 5

I was wondering in which circumstance do you recommend a person get psychological or psychiatric counseling? And if you do, it's so poisoned right now—like where does a person go? I don't know if that makes sense.

But it does. It does make sense. So you need to find a good Christian who's a counselor or a psychologist or a psychiatrist. Otherwise they can mess you up more than what you were originally messed up with. However, it's not embarrassing to look for it. It's not embarrassing to pray about it, and it's not embarrassing to accept some help. Like St. [Paisios], when his nuns were telling him, "I don't want to take medication because if God wants He will cure me," he would tell them, "You're proud." That's what he would tell them.

So if we need to get help, we need to get help. To find the right person, that's a different story. But the reality is that if we need help, we need help. You will understand from your reactions that someone else could have done it differently—maybe I need some advice. And counseling is really like trying to help guide your thoughts. And your spiritual father can help

you as well. But in some situations, if there is a chemical imbalance, your spiritual father cannot help you. So talk to your spiritual father and see if there is someone around that you could trust, an Orthodox person or a good Christian, and have a chat and see how it goes. You can test the waters and see how it goes, and always keep your spiritual father updated.

Our diocese does have a list of Christian mental health practitioners.

That would be great.

Yes. But what are the circumstances? Because just like you said, coming to the church and being in confession, if God wants to, for example, He can heal you in an instant, right? So I was just wondering how extreme does it have to be to risk going out and seeking counseling outside of the church?

Your experience will tell you. My experience taught me that although I could be considered a normal person all my life, the existence of [Geronda] in my life cured me. He didn't mean to, or maybe he did, I don't know. But his presence in my life cured me from insecurities, from trauma, from possible depression, from anxiety. Now I can see these traits in people. I can recognize them because I've been there, done that. But you need to pray to God to lead you to the right spiritual father and maybe to the right professional that can help you as well. God will provide. God will provide.

And why do I say that? It's not a coincidence that we meet the people that we meet. It's not like someone was born in Asia, I don't know, wherever, and they never heard about Christ—it's not a coincidence. It's not that God loves the place [less]. God gives us the opportunities we need for our personality to find Him when the time is right and under the right circumstances. So use what you have, which is yourself, in the sense that: God, this is who I am. Can You please help me go to the right path? He will do it. You're here. He will do it. Just follow it. Follow the peace of your heart. It will get you there. It's not brain surgery.

You see it in nature. You have the sun and you have a flower in the room close to a window. The flower will turn toward the sun. The peace of your soul will lead you where you need to be. Trusting this is God inside you. This is the Holy Spirit inside you. He will lead you. And then your spiritual father might verify. You will find your way. Otherwise God would not have created you. Does it make sense?

Yes. Yes.

It's not the easy way out. But God will lead you where you should be.

How do you properly examine yourself?

Processing the question, I would say that the only kind of examining I really need to do is watching the choices I make. Saying—like the catalog you do each evening of, did I fall short? Did I sin today? Do I need to repent of something and ask God's help with something for tomorrow?

I would sort of repeat myself. What Father said was very important, but I would again repeat myself and say that your inner peace will show you the way. So try to develop a deeper connection with God yourself through prayer, everyday prayer, whatever you can do. Talk to your spiritual father about it. And then God will meet you where you should be. It's not an accident. We're all here. We could have been in McDonald's. So God will lead you where you should be. Trust that.

And God knows, looking to analyze ourselves can get us to a certain point. Sometimes it could be confusing. [Geronda] used to say that we need to see God first and then find the strength to face ourselves. So if I try to understand myself with my own eyes, I can't. Why can't narcissists see themselves? They can't. They have eyes. They have mirrors. They can't. And when someone is telling them, "This is who you are," they can kill you because they can't accept it. We can't understand what's inside us. That's why I'm telling you to follow your peace, to find through spiritual father and through your prayer a connection with God. And the closer you go to the light, the more windows you open in the room of your soul, the more light goes in and shows you exactly where the dust is. And that's where you start understanding your insecurities, your faults, everything you should have done differently or could have done differently. And that's how you correct yourself. You can't see with your own eyes. Just focus on developing your connection with God and following your inner peace.

And something like—for example, a lot of times when it comes to medication, things like that, I think about—imagine you're working out and you get into a really bad habit of

working out the wrong way, and then you go visit a physical trainer. It's going to take time to correct you. So there are some people who, let's say, have OCD. This guy may need some sort of calming medication or whatever, because maybe he's in a place, and who he is and how he grew up and how he got to that point, he himself cannot face the mental knot that he has tied in the way he has thought. But then this person—in that same scenario—he could overcome it. But we have to remember that ultimately a doctor's goal is to protect human life and to heal human life.

And so if someone needs anxiety medication or something like that so they avoid, God forbid, hurting themselves, killing themselves, then it's better to take that route and then get off that one day, you know, because that might just be the very thing that ties your hands together so you don't hurt yourself. And I only say that out of personal experience. I never had to take medication, but I suffered really badly from OCD. And I remember there was a time—I'm in a lot better place than I was a while ago—but there was a time where I had absolutely no control of my thoughts and I was completely overburdened by these things, to the point where I actually was taking supplements like saffron and cumin. I was getting close to outright getting on medication. But it's like putting a Band-Aid on a huge wound.

So there is that spiritual aspect, like Father was saying, where it's like addressing—once you see God, you have to address yourself. But sometimes people are so—by the time they address themselves, they are so caught up in the ways of thinking, and they've gone through these certain—they've created like dendrites, they've created ways of thinking, ways of going around concepts, that's just unhealthy. And sometimes people have to numb themselves to undo that pain. It's like stretching a muscle that has been worked out for a long time, getting into a really bad habit. And maybe you don't have to do that. Maybe someone is strong enough, has that pain tolerance, that they can actually, without medication, endure that. But everybody's a different person.

And this makes me think of St. Luke. He was a doctor. You know what I mean? When we think medication, we think of the orange pill bottles that mess up your thyroid and—we're thinking of poison, right? But there are people who for years and years and years have made medication to help somebody, out of plants and things like that. Our generation has a very bitter taste in our mouth with this concept of medication because we think about big pharma, pharmacy people who want to poison us. So we're really disgusted with the people that God put in this world to help us, right, which are doctors. God compares—He's the Great Physician.

He's healing our spirit. He's popping our arm into place. He's doing whatever is broken in us spiritually. But God also made doctors and people that can help us. And that's why I think our generation is scared, because we're scared of putting our faith in people who we're afraid just want to profit off of our illness. That's probably where the hesitation comes from.

Part 6

So we are up against the end of our time here.

Yeah.

First of all, I'm sorry—your name?

What's your name?

Daniel.

Daniel. I guess what you said was very—yeah, it was very nice. I guess we do have a bitter taste in our mouth about medication. And I myself suffered a lot with anxiety growing up, very, very high anxiety. I would say a bit of depression as well. And so many years, as I saw my dad use a lot of these medications, I was like, “Never taking medications. They destroy people.” But it got to a point in my life where I just kept trying to find ways around my anxieties, to the point where I limited myself so much that I tied myself up. And if God wanted me to do something, I couldn't, because I tied myself up.

But if God wants to help you get somewhere, He puts you in a position—not to put you in an uncomfortable position on purpose—but He puts you in an uncomfortable position to be able to push you a bit forward. So it's a case of maybe taking medication, or as [was] said, being humble and taking something to help undo that, to get you to a level where you can do God's will. It's very important to do this, or to have this thought in your mind that everyone is out there to hurt you or try and do some sort of harm to you.

You know, I went to a very bad state even after I was ordained, before we would come to America, before we were to have our first child. My anxiety went through the roof, and I was scared of crying, and I had all these intrusive thoughts. I didn't sleep for like four days

straight. Four days straight. I couldn't sleep. [It got] worse. I remember calling His Grace, because he was in Greece. I was on the fourth day. I thought I was going mental. I couldn't pray. I couldn't function at that point. I was just praying, like just speaking, "God, please help me." I thought I was going to die at that point.

But God provided three people in that scenario that now, when I look back, I realize it was God's hand. God didn't help me the way I wanted. I was expecting a big miracle. But it doesn't happen like that. God gave me His grace, which [through] Father gave me an Orthodox doctor, and He gave me a [psychiatrist] to help me in that moment. All of these three people [worked] in sync. Usually I had them speaking for four days straight. I was calling at 3:00 a.m., 4:00 a.m., 2:00 a.m., and they all [helped] me to be able to reason. I'm here in America [because] if it wasn't following these people that God gave me, and the help of the medication, I wouldn't be here. My life would have been a mess.

So if there are people that want to help you, accept it, because maybe God put them there for a reason. And maybe God allowed you for a certain time to suffer anxiety and depression and certain things because it keeps us humble. And I believe that's what kept me close to the Church, even baptized from a young child. I didn't live the faith growing up because it was just, you know, "I'm baptized." I took it for granted. I didn't appreciate what I had. And if it wasn't for my anxiety, I don't think I would have stayed close to the Church. So God gives us things to keep us close.

Yeah. Yeah. After this I'll drop it. What's that story in the Bible where someone was just complaining to God and He gives him bread? He gives him bread, like he takes a nap. I forget—what was that? Was it Elijah or something?

I can't remember. But that's kind of what that made me think of, where it's like sometimes God can just make something go away, and sometimes He's just like, here, just take these things. Sometimes the world's material as well, so sometimes you just got to [accept help].

I will pray for God to protect me from my own thoughts and my own actions, but also guide me in the right direction. But I think asking for protection over your own thoughts and your own actions, because you sometimes feel like you can't even trust yourself, was very helpful for me too.

So we have Vespers starting like five minutes ago.

Okay. Yes.